

A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR HOMEOWNERS

Selling Your Home Yourself in Ohio

Pricing · Prep · Paperwork · Closing

What the process actually looks like, what Ohio law requires, and the mistakes that cost sellers the most.



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Serving Lima and the surrounding
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A quick note from me

You've decided to sell your house on your own. Good for you. It's a real job, and plenty of people do it well. This booklet is my attempt to hand you the things I wish every FSBO seller knew on day one: how pricing actually works, what Ohio law requires you to hand a buyer, what the contract says in plain English, and where the deals usually fall apart.

There's no pitch in here. I put my name on the back in case you ever want a second set of eyes on a price or an offer. That call is free, and it doesn't come with a listing appointment attached.

A little about me, so you know who's talking: I've lived and worked in Northwest Ohio for most of my life. Before real estate I spent 18 years as a cardiac nurse and 26 years in the Air National Guard. I'm a Dad, a Veteran, and your neighbor. I'm the kind of person who'd rather give a straight answer than a sales answer, and that's how this guide is written.

Use what helps. Skip what doesn't. And keep the checklist on the last page on your fridge.

— Scott

How to use this guide

Read pages 4–5 first (pricing) even if you already have a number in mind. Pricing is the single decision that determines whether the rest of this goes smoothly. Then work the sections in order as you go: prep, marketing, paperwork, showings, contract, closing.

What the numbers say

The National Association of REALTORS® surveys home sellers every year. Here's what the most recent report (2025) found about sellers who went it alone:

5% of home sales were for-sale-by-owner	\$360K median FSBO price vs. \$425K agent-assisted	40% of FSBO sellers did not actively market the home
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The price gap is not proof that agents are magic. Some of it is the kind of home and the kind of buyer. But it points at the three places FSBO sellers said they struggled most: **setting the right price, getting the home ready, and selling in the time they wanted.**

Those three are fixable, and this guide is built around them. The 40% number is the one I'd take personally: nearly half of FSBO sellers never really put the house in front of buyers. If you do nothing else, don't be in that 40%.

The most common FSBO ending

About one in five FSBO sellers eventually lists with an agent to get the deal done, usually after the house has sat and the price has been cut. The goal of this booklet is to help you avoid that. The number on the back is there if you don't.

Source: NAR 2025 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers.

STEP 1

Pricing it right

Buyers in our area see every new listing within hours, and they compare. A house priced right draws showings in the first two weeks. A house priced high draws silence, then a price cut, then a lower final number than if it had started right.

How to comp your own house

A comparable sale (a "comp") is a home that a real buyer actually paid for. Not a listing. Not an estimate. A closed sale.

- **Same area.** Same neighborhood or school district, ideally within a mile in town, a few miles rural.
- **Recent.** Closed in the last 6 months. Older than that and the market has moved.
- **Similar bones.** Within about 20% of your square footage, same style (ranch vs. two-story), similar age, similar lot.
- **Three to five of them.** One comp is a story. Four is a pattern.

Where to find them: your county auditor's website (most in our area publish recent sales), Zillow's "sold" filter, or ask me and I'll pull the MLS sheet for you at no charge.

Then adjust, honestly

Your house is not the comp. Adjust for what's different: an extra bath, a newer roof, a finished basement, a two-car garage, a busy road. Adjust down as readily as up. The buyer will.

The Zestimate trap

Online estimates are a starting point, not a price. They don't know your roof is 22 years old or that your kitchen was redone last year. In small Ohio markets with fewer sales they can miss by 10% or more in either direction.

Three pricing mistakes that cost the most

- **"Leave room to negotiate."** Buyers don't negotiate with a house they never walk through. Overpricing by 5-8% doesn't create room; it removes showings.
- **Pricing off what you need.** Your payoff, your next down payment, and what you spent on the deck are real to you and invisible to the buyer.
- **Chasing the market down.** Small cuts every few weeks signal a seller who'll keep cutting. If it isn't moving after 3 weeks of real exposure, make one meaningful correction.

Read the market's answer

The market tells you if you're right within about 14 days:

- **Showings but no offers** → you're close; the house or condition is talking buyers out of it.
- **Few or no showings** → the price is filtering people out before they ever come.
- **Multiple offers in days** → you may have left money on the table. It happens.

Price brackets matter

Buyers search in ranges: "up to \$200,000" or "\$200,000-\$250,000." A house at \$204,900 is invisible to the first group and looks cheap to the second. Price at or just under the bracket, not just over it.

Free, no-strings pricing opinion

If you want a second opinion before you commit to a number, call or text me. I'll pull the actual comps and walk you through them over the phone. You don't have to list with anyone to get that.

STEP 2

Getting it ready

Buyers decide in the first 8 seconds on the screen and the first 60 seconds at the door. Preparation isn't about making the house perfect; it's about removing the reasons to say no.

The high-return list (do these first)

- ☐ Declutter every flat surface. Half of what's on your counters and shelves goes into boxes now.
- ☐ Deep clean, including windows, baseboards, and the inside of the oven. Hire it out if you can — it's the best \$200 you'll spend.
- ☐ Neutral touch-up paint where walls are scuffed. Fill nail holes.
- ☐ Fix the small stuff a buyer's inspector will list anyway: dripping faucets, loose handrails, missing outlet covers, a running toilet.
- ☐ Replace burnt-out bulbs; use the same warm-white color in every fixture.
- ☐ Curb appeal: mow, edge, mulch, trim, power-wash the walk, and put a new mat at the front door.
- ☐ Smell check. Ask a friend who doesn't live there. Pets, smoke, and basement damp are deal-killers you've stopped noticing.

Skip these

Major kitchen or bath remodels rarely return their cost right before a sale. New carpet in one bad room, yes. A \$30,000 kitchen, no.

Photos: the part most FSBOs get wrong

Your photos are your open house. Most buyers will never see the inside if the pictures don't get them there.

- **Hire a real estate photographer if at all possible.** In our area it runs roughly \$150-\$250 and it's the highest-return dollar in this whole process.
- If you shoot it yourself: phone in landscape, held at chest height, every light on, blinds open, shoot in daytime, stand in the corner of each room.
- Turn off the TV, close toilet lids, hide the trash can and the dish rack, take the magnets off the fridge.
- Lead with the exterior, then the kitchen, then the living room. 20-30 photos. No blurry ones — cut them.

Before showings

Have a five-minute "show ready" routine you can run every time: lights on, blinds open, dishes away, beds made, pets out, soft music off, temperature comfortable. Then leave. Buyers won't talk honestly in front of the owner, and honest reactions are what you need.

Pre-listing inspection?

Paying for your own inspection (\$350-\$450) before you list means no surprises during the buyer's inspection, which is where more FSBO deals die than anywhere else. Fix what you can, disclose what you can't, and price accordingly.

STEP 3

Getting it in front of buyers

Remember the 40%. A sign in the yard reaches the people who drive past. The buyers who'll pay the most are the ones searching online tonight from Columbus, Dayton, or Fort Wayne.

Where buyers actually look

- **Zillow.** You can post a FSBO listing free. It shows up in the "other listings" section, not the main feed, so it draws less traffic than an MLS listing — but it's the biggest single audience you can reach on your own.
- **Facebook Marketplace and local groups.** Strong across our area. Post good photos and a clear price; answer messages fast.
- **A professional yard sign** with a phone number readable from a moving car.
- **Flat-fee MLS.** Third-party services will put your home on the MLS for a few hundred dollars. You'll show up on every site and in front of every agent's buyers. Read the fine print on what you're paying.

Write the listing like a buyer, not an owner

Lead with the facts buyers filter on: beds, baths, square footage, garage, lot size, year built, school district, taxes. Then 3–4 sentences on what's actually notable: the new roof, the updated furnace, the fenced yard. Skip "cozy" and "must see."

Have your numbers ready

Every serious buyer will ask: annual property taxes, average utility costs, age of roof/furnace/AC/water heater, and what's staying (appliances, window treatments). Write them on one sheet and keep copies by the door.

STEP 4

Ohio paperwork you can't skip

This is where selling on your own carries real legal risk. Two documents are required in almost every residential sale in Ohio, agent or not.

1. Residential Property Disclosure Form

Ohio law (R.C. 5302.30) requires you to complete the state's disclosure form and give it to the buyer **before** they sign a purchase contract. You disclose what you actually know about the property: water, sewer, roof, basement, structural, mechanical, pests, drainage, boundary issues, and more.

- Fill it out yourself, honestly and completely. "Unknown" is a legitimate answer; a blank or a guess is not.
- If a buyer doesn't get the form before signing, they can **cancel the contract** within 3 business days of receiving it (until closing). Late delivery is how FSBO deals unravel.
- Download the current form free from the Ohio Department of Commerce, Division of Real Estate. Or call me and I'll send you a copy.

2. Lead-based paint disclosure (homes built before 1978)

Federal law requires a separate lead disclosure form, the EPA pamphlet *Protect Your Family From Lead in Your Home*, and a 10-day window for the buyer to test if they want. Both parties sign and keep a copy. A large share of the housing stock in our area is pre-1978, so this applies to most FSBO sellers.

Disclosure protects you, too

A disclosed defect is the buyer's decision. An undisclosed one is a lawsuit after closing. When in doubt, write it down.

STEP 5

The purchase contract, in plain English

Ohio has no single statewide form. Agents use forms from their local REALTOR® association; a FSBO seller needs a contract from a title company or a real estate attorney. Do not download a random form off the internet. Whatever form you use, here's what the main sections mean:

- **Purchase price and financing.** Cash, or a loan with a stated type (conventional, FHA, VA, USDA) and a deadline for the buyer to get approved. FHA/VA/USDA loans have their own property condition rules.
- **Earnest money.** The buyer's good-faith deposit, typically \$500–\$2,000 in our area, held by the title company — never by you.
- **Inspection contingency.** Usually 7–10 days. The buyer can inspect, ask for repairs or credits, or walk. Expect a repair request; decide in advance what you'll give.
- **Appraisal contingency.** If the lender's appraisal comes in low, the buyer can renegotiate or walk. Pricing right protects you here.
- **Sale of buyer's home.** If the buyer must sell first, ask for a kick-out clause so you can keep showing.
- **What conveys.** Appliances, window treatments, the shed, the swing set. List it or expect an argument at the walk-through.
- **Closing date and possession.** Typically 30–45 days for a financed buyer. Say exactly when you hand over keys.
- **Title and closing costs.** Who pays for what (see page 13).

Have someone read it before you sign

A local real estate attorney will review a contract for a few hundred dollars. Compared to the size of this transaction, that's cheap insurance.

STEP 6

Showings, safety, and buyer's agents

Showings

- Ask for a name, phone number, and a lender pre-approval letter (or proof of funds for cash) before you open the door. Serious buyers have one.
- Never show alone if you can help it. Have someone else in the house or on the phone. Leave valuables, medications, and mail out of sight.
- Give buyers space. Greet them, point out the two or three things they might miss, then step outside or into the yard.
- Keep a simple sign-in sheet and follow up the next day with a text: "Thanks for coming — any questions?"

When a buyer's agent calls

Many buyers work with an agent even when the house is FSBO. Since 2024, buyers sign a written agreement with their agent that spells out what the agent is paid. The agent may ask whether you'll pay some or all of that, usually as a seller concession in the offer.

- You are not required to. But refusing outright shrinks your buyer pool — decide your position before the first call, not during it.
- A common middle ground: "I'll consider it as part of an offer." Then evaluate the offer's net to you, not its headline price.
- Ohio agents will give you an Agency Disclosure form showing who they represent. They represent the buyer, not you. Be friendly; don't over-share (your bottom line, your timeline, your reasons for selling).

Fair housing applies to you

Advertise the house, not the buyer you'd prefer. Don't describe the "ideal family" or the church down the street. Treat every prospect the same.

STEP 7

From accepted offer to keys

A typical financed sale in our area takes 30–45 days from accepted offer to closing. Cash can close in two weeks. Here's what's happening in between:

Day 0	Offer accepted Both sign. Buyer delivers earnest money to the title company within a few days.
Days 1–10	Inspection Buyer's inspector visits (2–3 hours). Expect a repair/credit request. Negotiate in writing; keep it small and specific.
Days 5–20	Appraisal & loan Lender orders appraisal. Buyer's underwriting proceeds. Respond fast to any document requests that touch you.
Days 10–30	Title work Title company searches the title, clears liens, orders payoff from your lender, prepares the deed.
Days 25–40	Clear to close Lender issues final approval. Title company sends a settlement statement showing your exact net. Read every line.
Day before	Final walk-through Buyer confirms the house is in the agreed condition and agreed items are there. Have it clean and empty.
Closing day	Sign & fund You sign the deed and closing documents (often a separate appointment). Funds wire after recording. Hand over keys as the contract says.

Wire fraud is real

Never send or accept wiring instructions by email without calling the title company at a number you looked up yourself to confirm. Sellers have lost entire proceeds this way.

STEP 8

What it actually costs to sell

"No commission" doesn't mean "no costs." Plan for these so the settlement statement isn't a surprise. Customs vary by county; your title company will confirm.

Typical seller-side costs in our area

- **Ohio conveyance fee.** State plus county, commonly \$3–\$4 per \$1,000 of sale price. On \$200,000, that's \$600–\$800. Seller customarily pays.
- **Owner's title insurance policy.** A buyer may ask you to pay it in their offer, but you are never obligated to. It's negotiable, and in our area buyers rarely request it.
- **Title exam, deed preparation, closing/settlement fee.** Roughly \$300–\$700 combined.
- **Property tax proration.** Ohio taxes are paid *in arrears*, so you'll credit the buyer for taxes covering the time you owned the home but that aren't billed yet. This one surprises almost every FSBO seller.
- **Mortgage payoff**, including interest through the funding date, and any recording fee for the release.
- **Negotiated items.** Repair credits from inspection, any buyer's-agent compensation you agreed to, a home warranty if offered.
- **Your own costs.** Photos, sign, flat-fee MLS, attorney review, pre-listing inspection, cleaning.

Ask for a seller net sheet

Any title company will estimate your net proceeds before you accept an offer. I'll run one for you too — free, same day — so you're comparing offers on what you'll actually walk away with.

When it's time to get help

Plenty of FSBO sales go smoothly start to finish. The ones that don't usually get stuck in one of these places. None of them means you failed; they mean the market or the process needs something you can't easily do alone.

- **Three weeks, real exposure, no offers.** The house has been seen and passed over. Something about price or condition needs a change you're too close to see.
- **Showings that go nowhere.** Buyers come, say nice things, and vanish. You're not getting the honest feedback an agent would get from the other agent.
- **An offer you can't read.** Contingencies, concessions, a home-sale clause, an escalation addendum. Don't guess.
- **The inspection turned into a renegotiation.** A \$6,000 repair list and a buyer threatening to walk is where experience matters most.
- **The buyer's financing fell through** and you're now on a deadline of your own: a job start, a house you've already bought, a divorce settlement.
- **You're just done.** Showings on weekends, strangers in your house, the phone at 9 p.m. That's a legitimate reason.

What working with me actually looks like

MLS exposure to every buyer and agent in the region, professional photos, pricing off real comps, negotiation with the other side's agent, and someone whose job is to keep the closing on the rails. My compensation is negotiable and we'd talk about it openly, in dollars, before you signed anything.

Or don't hire anyone

If you want to keep going on your own, call anyway. I'll tell you what I'd change and you can do it yourself. I'd rather be useful than be hired.

The FSBO checklist

Before you list

- ☐ Pull 3–5 closed comps and set a price at or just under a search bracket
- ☐ Complete the Ohio Residential Property Disclosure Form
- ☐ Lead-paint disclosure + EPA pamphlet ready (pre-1978 homes)
- ☐ One-page fact sheet: taxes, utilities, ages of roof/HVAC/water heater, what stays
- ☐ Declutter, deep clean, touch-up paint, fix the small stuff
- ☐ Professional photos (or the phone routine on page 7)
- ☐ Contract from a title company or attorney, reviewed
- ☐ Decide your position on buyer's-agent compensation

While it's on the market

- ☐ Listed on Zillow FSBO, Facebook, yard sign (consider flat-fee MLS)
- ☐ Pre-approval or proof of funds before every showing
- ☐ Show-ready routine; owner out of the house during showings
- ☐ Sign-in sheet; next-day follow-up text
- ☐ Evaluate offers on net proceeds, not headline price — get a net sheet

Under contract

- ☐ Earnest money delivered to the title company
- ☐ Inspection response in writing by the deadline
- ☐ Respond same-day to title company and lender requests
- ☐ Confirm wiring instructions by phone, never email alone
- ☐ Walk-through ready: clean, empty, agreed items in place
- ☐ Keys, garage remotes, codes, and manuals in a bag on the counter



Questions? Just call.

No listing appointment. No pitch. If you want a second opinion on your price, a copy of the Ohio disclosure form, or a straight answer about an offer you're looking at, that's a five-minute phone call and it's free.



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